these visits, except to Bhutan and Myanmar, and the presence of a lady in the delegation made a world of a difference, making social interactions that much more informal. Through the interactions between the ladies, it also enabled us to get a feel of how families of service personnel are looked after in their respective countries, something which would not have been possible in an all-male delegation.

The first visit in 2020 itself was to Nepal where I was to be conferred with the honorary rank of General of the Nepali Army. This is a unique and reciprocal tradition between the Nepali Army and the Indian Army, possibly the only such arrangement in the world. During the visit, I was conferred this title at their Rashtrapati Bhawan, Shital Niwas, by the President of Nepal, the Honourable Bidya Devi Bhandari, who served as the second president of Nepal from 2015 to 2023 and was the first woman to hold this office in the country. Nepal–India ties had hit a new low earlier in the year over Kalapani, over which both India and Nepal lay claim.[1] The dispute came to the fore when in November 2019, India published a revised political map showing the newly created Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh. The map showed Kalapani as part of the Pithoragarh district of Uttarakhand. Nepal protested immediately and drew attention to the lingering issue. On 8 May, India inaugurated the Darchula–Lipulekh Pass link road, cutting across the disputed Kalapani area that is used by Indian pilgrims to Kailash Manasarovar. Nepal hit back by summoning the Indian Ambassador to Nepal, Shri Vinay Mohan Kwatra, to convey a formal protest.[2] Against this backdrop, my visit and the conferment of the rank of Honorary General signalled a thaw in the relations and paved the way for a resumption of diplomatic initiatives. We also gifted to the Nepali Army three ambulances and equipment for two field

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